

In the Edexcel A Level Business exam, "**Analyse**" is a specific command word that asks you to demonstrate **A03 (Analysis)**. Essentially, it means you need to show **chains of reasoning**. You aren't just stating a fact; you are explaining the "domino effect" of a business decision or situation.

The Anatomy of an Analysis Question

- **Marks:** Usually **6 marks** (though analysis is a massive component of 10, 12, and 20-mark questions too).
 - **The Goal:** Show how one thing leads to another, and another, until you reach a final impact on the business (like profit, survival, or brand image).
 - **The Golden Rule:** Never leave a "logical gap." The examiner shouldn't have to guess how you got from Point A to Point B.
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The "BLT" Method (A Student Favorite)

To get full marks in an Edexcel analysis question, many teachers recommend the **BLT** sandwich:

- **B - Because:** Give a reason or a cause based on the case study.
 - **L - Leading to:** Explain the immediate consequence of that reason.
 - **T - Therefore:** Explain the final impact on the business's objectives.
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Example: A 6-Mark Question

Question: *Analyse one benefit to Apple of using a premium pricing strategy for the iPhone.*

Step	What to Write (The Chain)
The Point	One benefit of premium pricing is that it creates a high-quality brand image.
Context (AO2)	Because the iPhone is marketed as a high-end technological device...
Analysis Step 1	...this leads to high profit margins on every unit sold compared to budget competitors like Samsung's A-series.
Analysis Step 2	Consequently, this generates significant retained profit for Apple...
The Impact	...which therefore allows them to reinvest in R&D to maintain their competitive advantage in the smartphone market.

Common Pitfalls to Avoid

- **The "List" Trap:** Don't list three different benefits. For an "Analyse" question, it is much better to explain **one or two benefits in great depth** than five benefits briefly.
 - **Ignoring the Context:** If the question is about a specific business (e.g., "Analysing Zara's supply chain"), you **must** use information from the case study. If your answer could apply to *any* business in the world, you will lose marks for lack of "Application" (AO2).
 - **Adding a Conclusion:** For a standalone 6-mark "Analyse" question, **do not write a conclusion**. You don't get marks for evaluation (judging if it's a good or bad idea), and you'll just waste precious time.
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Check-list for your answer:

1. [] Did I use a connective (e.g., *"This leads to..."*, *"As a result..."*)?
2. [] Is there a "chain" of at least 3-4 steps?
3. [] Did I mention the specific business/product from the case study?
4. [] Did I end with a final impact (e.g., *"Therefore, profit increases"*)?

In Edexcel A Level Business, **"Evaluate"** is the highest-level command word. It asks you to demonstrate **AO4 (Evaluation)**.

While "Analyse" is about building a chain of reasoning, "Evaluate" is about **judging** that chain. You are effectively acting as a consultant: you look at the pros and cons, the risks and rewards, and then make a final recommendation.

The Difference: Analyse vs. Evaluate

Feature	Analyse (AO3)	Evaluate (AO4)
Goal	Explain <i>how</i> something happens.	Judge <i>how much</i> it matters.
Direction	One-way (A to B to C).	Two-way (On one hand... however...).
Conclusion	Not required.	Essential.
Analogy	Describing how an engine works.	Deciding if this is the right car to buy.

The "AJIM" Framework

To score high marks (Level 4) in 10, 12, or 20-mark questions, you need a strong structure. Most examiners look for the **AJIM** approach in your conclusion:

1. **A - Answer:** Directly answer the question (e.g., "Yes, this was a good strategy" or "No, the risks outweigh the benefits").
 2. **J - Justification:** Briefly recap your strongest reason why.
 3. **I - It Depends On:** This is the "secret sauce" for top marks. What does the success of this decision depend on? (e.g., "It depends on how the competition reacts" or "It depends on the state of the economy").
 4. **M - Most Important Factor:** Identify the single most critical variable that will decide if this succeeds or fails.
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The "MOPS" Strategy (For the "It Depends")

If you are struggling to think of **evaluation** points, use the **MOPS** acronym to find things the business's success "depends on":

- **M - Market:** Is the market growing or shrinking? Is it highly competitive?
 - **O - Objectives:** Is the business trying to survive (short term) or grow (long term)?
 - **P - Product:** Is it a luxury "want" or a basic "need"?
 - **S - Situation:** What is the financial state of the business? Do they have the cash to do this?
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Example Conclusion for a 20-mark question: *"Evaluate whether Apple should prioritize price skimming for its next product launch."*

- **A - Answer:** Overall, price skimming is the most effective strategy for Apple's next launch.
- **J - Justification:** This is because Apple's brand image is built on exclusivity and high-end technology, allowing them to maximize revenue from "early adopters" before competitors can react.
- **I - It Depends On:** However, the success of this **depends on** the **Market** and the degree of innovation in the new product. If the product is only a minor update, customers may switch to cheaper competitors like Samsung.
- **M - Most Important Factor:** The **Most Important Factor** is the **Situation** regarding Apple's R&D pipeline. If the new product offers a genuine "technological leap," price skimming will succeed regardless of the price point because the "want" outweighs the "need".

Enhancing Analysis (AO3): The "Connective" Expansion

While the **BLT** (Because, Leading to, Therefore) method is excellent, examiners look for variety in your "chains of reasoning". To ensure you don't leave a "logical gap", use these expanded connectives:

- **To show a negative chain:** *"This could lead to... which may result in... and ultimately causes..."*
 - **To show a positive chain:** *"This enables the business to... consequently... which results in..."*
 - **Tip for Level 4:** Aim for at least **five "links"** in your chain for 20-mark questions to demonstrate "great depth".
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Enhancing Evaluation (AO4): Magnitude and Timeframe

To push your evaluation from a basic "However" into a top-tier "supported judgment," consider these two extra layers:

- **Magnitude:** How big is the impact? (e.g., *"While this costs money, the impact is small compared to Zara's multi-billion dollar revenue"*).
 - **Timeframe (Short-term vs. Long-term):** Does the decision help now but hurt later? (e.g., *"In the short term, premium pricing boosts margins, but in the long term, it may limit market share growth"*).
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Refining the "Context" (AO2) Requirement

The sources warn against the "List Trap" and "Ignoring Context". To make your answer "better" for Edexcel, you must **embed the context** into the chain itself, not just at the start.

- **Poor Context:** "Apple sells phones, so they should use premium pricing."
 - **Strong Context (AO2):** "Because the **iPhone** is marketed as a **high-end technological device**, using premium pricing reinforces its status. This is vital because **smartphone** users often view price as a proxy for quality."
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What a 20-Mark Structure Looks Like

For the big questions, your essay should look like a balanced scale:

- **Introduction:** Define key terms and state your initial stance.
 - **Paragraph 1: Analysis** of the first option/benefit (using BLT chains).
 - **Paragraph 2: Counter-argument** (The "However..." – why this might not work).
 - **Paragraph 3: Analysis** of the second option/drawback.
 - **Paragraph 4: Counter-argument** (Another "However...").
 - **Conclusion (AJIM):** Your final judgment.
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The Golden Rule for Evaluation: You cannot get into the top mark band (Level 4) if you do not provide a "supported judgment." This means your conclusion must be more than one sentence; it must explain *why* you chose that side over the other.